that the Soviet Union is encircled by a chain of American military bases.

These bases are full of nuclear weapons. Their mission is well known. They are targeted at us. Nothing like it can be found around your country.

And what about entire regions of the globe being proclaimed as spheres of American vital interest and also made subject to U.S. military presence?

This is done, among other places, at our very doorstep. We, on our part, do not do anything like that. What conclusions should we draw from this as to the intentions of the United States? The conclusions readily present themselves: This course of action is nothing but a hyperatrophied idea of one's interests when the legitimate interests of others are completely ignored. Nothing but an urge to gain, to put it mildly, positions of privilege at the expense of the other side. This course of action is not in line with the course of assuring stability; on the contrary, such a course and policy objectively helps to create and maintain tensions. . . .

That no claims can be laid to the Soviet Union for the fact there is a rough parity between the USSR and the USA and in a wider sense between the members of the Warsaw Treaty and NATO can be disputed by no expert familiar with the state of affairs. The SALT II treaty embodied that fact. It was not the end of the road and we did not think it was. But the merit of the treaty was that, among other things, that it stated, I would say with mathematical precision, the existing strategic balance.

I remind you that it was the Soviet Union that offered to reduce their number to the minimum on the side of the USSR and NATO. And in response, Pershing and cruise missiles appeared in the vicinity of our borders.